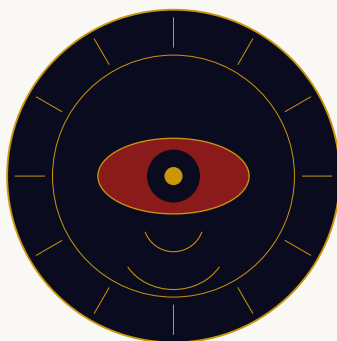




THE BLOOD OF FORGOTTEN GODS

A Supernatural Dark Fantasy

Istanbul, 1893

AIRID

THE BLOOD OF FORGOTTEN GODS

Book One



“The old gods did not die. They simply stopped being named.”

AIRID

Author & Editor

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Book One of The Blood of Forgotten Gods series

Written and edited by Airid

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PART ONE



THE UNMARKED GIRL

The Weight of Smoke

The morning Nura Kaya's hands first bled light, she was elbow-deep in the dye vats of her uncle's workshop, and she assumed she was dying.

It was September of 1893, and the air over Istanbul tasted of salt and coal smoke and the particular anxiety of an empire trying to convince itself it was not ending. Nura was seventeen years old and had spent most of those years being unremarkable in the specific way of girls whose mothers die young—she existed in the margins of other people's lives, useful and overlooked, learning to want very little and expect less.

The dye vat was indigo that morning. The color her mother had loved. Nura had her sleeves rolled to the elbow, stirring the enormous copper pot with a wooden paddle longer than her arm, watching the cloth churn and swallow the blue. Her uncle Kerem was at the front of the shop arguing with a merchant from the Covered Bazaar about a late delivery, his voice carrying the particular strained patience of a man who needs this sale. Her cousin Yildiz was supposed to be helping but had slipped away twenty minutes ago and would not return until she was needed to lie about where she had been.

Nura did not mind. She had grown up covering for Yildiz the same way she had grown up doing most things—quietly, thoroughly, without expecting gratitude. It was the shape her life had taken and she had learned to find a kind of peace inside it, the way water finds its level.

She was thinking about nothing in particular when the warmth started.

Not the warmth of the vat—she was accustomed to that, the wet heat that climbed her arms and fogged the air around her face. This warmth was underneath. Inside the skin of her palms, moving upward through her wrists like something waking after a long sleep. She frowned and looked down and saw the light seeping from the creases of her knuckles, gold-white and pulsing gently, as if her hands had swallowed a lantern.

She did not scream. This, she would think later, was either very brave or very stupid. She simply stared at her glowing hands with the detached focus of someone trying to solve a problem they do not yet understand, while the indigo water around them began to churn in slow spirals that had nothing to do with the paddle she had dropped.

Then the vat cracked down its center seam—a clean split, as if something had pressed outward from inside—and thirty liters of indigo dye rushed across the workshop floor, and the light went out of her hands as suddenly as it had come, and Nura was left kneeling in a spreading pool of blue with a split copper pot and no explanation that her uncle would believe.

He didn't believe the one she gave him either. An accident, she said. I lost my grip on the paddle and it struck the seam. Kerem looked at her with the expression of a man who knows he is being lied to but cannot afford the time it would take to establish the truth. He docked three weeks of her wages for the pot. She accepted this.

But that night, alone on her sleeping mat with the smell of indigo still in her hair, she opened her right hand in the dark and waited.

Nothing came.

She waited longer. Still nothing—just her own ordinary palm, the calluses from the paddle, the faint blue stain that would not wash out for days. She closed her hand. She told herself she had imagined it. She was very good at telling herself things and almost as good at believing them.

She did not imagine it.

The Man Who Collected Impossibilities

His name, as far as the city knew it, was Efendi Carim—though the city knew very little about him, which was, Nura would learn, entirely by design.

He appeared at the dye workshop four days after the incident with the vat, which she did not think was a coincidence. He was perhaps fifty, perhaps older—the kind of man whose age was difficult to determine because everything about him was deliberately unreadable. He wore a European suit of very good dark wool under a kaftan of equal quality, a combination that suggested someone who had decided to refuse the choice between worlds. His face was angular and still, his eyes the color of old amber, and he moved through the workshop with the particular attention of someone who was looking for something specific and knew exactly where it was.

He said he needed twelve bolts of cloth dyed in a particular shade of red—not crimson, not scarlet, a very specific dark red that he described with technical precision that made her uncle blink. He produced a sample swatch and the conversation moved to prices, and Nura went back to her work at the sorting table and forgot about him.

Until he stopped beside her on his way out.

He did not speak immediately. He simply stood close enough that she could see the fabric of his kaftan, a dark silk with a pattern worked into it in a slightly darker thread—geometric, repeating, oddly difficult to focus on directly. Then

he said, very quietly, in the educated Istanbul Turkish of someone who had learned it as a second language: The hands. Have they done it again?

She did not look up from the cloth she was sorting. What hands.

He made a sound that was not quite a laugh. He set something on the sorting table beside her work—a card, she saw, when she finally looked. Heavy cream paper, embossed with an address in the Beyoglu district and a symbol she did not recognize: an eye, open, with radiating lines.

When you are ready to understand what you are, he said, come and find me. He paused. Before it happens somewhere you cannot contain it.

She watched him leave without responding. She watched her uncle bow and shake the man's hand and tell him the order would be ready in three weeks. She watched the workshop door close.

Then she picked up the card and put it in the pocket of her apron, under the fold where Yildiz would not find it when she borrowed the apron without asking, which she did every Thursday.

She held it there for eleven days.

On the twelfth day, she was in the covered market buying thread when the light came back—both hands this time, the full palms, and a merchant three stalls away saw it and pointed and said something in Armenian that she did not understand but whose meaning was clear enough from his face. She closed her fists and walked out of the market at a pace she refused to let become a run and did not stop until she was two streets away, and even then she kept her hands in her pockets.

That evening she took out the card and read the address again.

She went the following morning before she could talk herself out of it.

The House Behind the Compass Rose

The address led her to a building in Beyoglu that she must have walked past a hundred times without seeing—or rather, without noticing, which she was beginning to understand were different things.

It sat between a French patisserie and a Greek shipping office on a street of mixed European facades, and it was the only building on the block without a sign above its door. The door itself was heavy dark wood with a brass knocker in the shape of an open hand, fingers spread, lines of the palm deeply incised. She was becoming familiar with the motif.

She knocked. A young man answered—younger than she expected, perhaps her own age, with a shaved head and the ink-black tattoo of something geometric curling from behind his left ear down to his collar. He looked at her hands before her face. Then he stood aside and let her in.

The interior was not what the exterior suggested. The building's face was narrow, three windows wide, but the inside opened into a depth and height that seemed impossible given the footprint—high ceilings with plasterwork of unusual intricacy, walls lined from floor to ceiling with shelves holding jars, tubes, rolled documents, objects she could not name. The light came from lamps of a design she had not seen before, burning with a steadiness that was not quite right for oil and not quite electric.

Efendi Carim was waiting in a room at the back, seated at a desk of extraordinary age covered in papers and instruments. He rose when she entered and dismissed the young man with a gesture.

You took longer than I expected, he said. There was no reproach in it—more the note of a man checking a calculation.

I needed eleven days to decide you were not dangerous, she said. I decided wrong but came anyway.

He smiled then, for the first time she had seen, and it changed his face significantly. Please sit. Would you like tea?

She sat. She wanted tea badly—it had been a long walk—but she said: Tell me what I am first.

He looked at her with what she would later recognize as respect. He brought the tea anyway, which she accepted, and then he sat across from her and folded his hands and began.

What she was, he told her, was a Vasita—a word with no clean translation into everyday Turkish, coming from an older tongue. Literally it meant something close to vessel, but the meaning was more precise than that: a person whose body could hold and channel the energies that had once belonged to the old gods. The gods who had preceded all the named ones—before Allah, before Christ, before the Greek pantheon built their marble arguments on older foundations. The gods who had not died but had merely dispersed, become diffuse, their power scattered into bloodlines, into places, into objects, into the spaces between things.

Most Vasita never knew what they were, he said. The ability was latent. It required a trigger—sometimes a great shock, sometimes proximity to an object of power, sometimes simply the right age and the right accumulation of suppressed use. Your mother, he added, carefully, was also a Vasita. She was rather stronger than you are showing yet. He paused. She died before she could tell you.

Nura set down her tea. The cup made a small sound against the saucer. How do you know about my mother.

It was not a question. He answered it anyway.

I knew her, he said. We worked together for four years. Her name was Handan Kaya and she could read stone—not the writing carved into it, but the memory inside it. Every stone that has ever been part of a significant place holds an impression, like a photograph, of what it witnessed. She could access those impressions by touch. It was a very rare ability. He was quiet for a moment. She was the most careful person I have ever known. That she died when she did was not carelessness. It was something else.

Something else, Nura repeated.

Yes. He met her eyes. This is the part of the conversation I was hoping to avoid.

What Lives in the Walls of Old Cities

There were things in Istanbul that were not human, and most of them were very old.

This was how Efendi Carim—whose real name was, he finally told her, Iskender Aras, and who had been many things in his sixty-one years including a physician, a forger of documents, and the founder of a small society dedicated to the study and management of what he called the residue—explained the city to her. Not as the sum of its minarets and markets and warring European interests, not as a crossroads of civilization, but as a deep place. A place where the old energies were thick in the foundations because so many civilizations had built their significant things on top of each other, each one pressing the previous deeper, each one unknowingly compressing the power of what it buried.

Constantinople before Istanbul. Byzantium before Constantinople. Before that, older settlements whose names were known only in the archives he kept in this building. Each era of construction pressing the previous down into the bedrock, creating a kind of temporal stratification of power that made Istanbul unlike almost any other city on earth.

And in those deep strata, he told her, things survived.

He did not call them monsters. He called them remnants—fragments of divine energy that had been too concentrated to fully disperse when the gods they belonged to ceased to be worshipped. Without worship to give them definition and direction, they lost their minds, their specificity, their original

nature. What remained was hunger and power without form—entities that could reshape themselves into whatever fear or desire they found in the minds of the humans they encountered.

Most of the time, he said, they were contained. The thickness of the city above them—the centuries of daily human life, the noise and movement and faith of millions of people—acted as a kind of weight, pressing them down. But there were places where the containment weakened. Old cisterns. Certain stretches of ancient wall. The undersides of the oldest mosques, built on foundations of older temples, built on foundations of older sacred sites still.

He and his small society—the residue, as they sometimes called themselves after the phenomenon they studied—monitored these weak points. They had been doing so for decades. And lately, he told her, the monitoring had become urgent.

There is a specific remnant, he said. One that has been dormant for a very long time—since the fall of Constantinople, as near as I can date it. It was bound then, by a Vasita who had sufficient power to perform a binding of that scope. The binding was never meant to be permanent. It was a measure bought against the need to complete a permanent solution, which the Vasita in question died before she could accomplish. He stopped.

I see where this is going, Nura said.

Do you.

You are about to tell me that the binding is weakening. And that my mother was the person who was supposed to deal with it. And that she died before she could. She looked at him steadily. And now you have found me, and I have her ability, and you need someone to finish what she started.

The situation is somewhat more complicated than that, he said. But the essential architecture of what you have just described is correct.

She stood up.

Give me two days, she said. I need to tell my uncle I will not be coming back to the workshop.

He blinked. You are not going to ask why I couldn't find someone else? Whether I have truly exhausted every other option?

She picked up her shawl. You came to a seventeen-year-old dye girl. I assume you have exhausted every other option.

She was almost to the door before he spoke again. Your mother left something for you, he said. In the event that we ever found you. I have been keeping it for three years.

Nura stopped. She kept her back to him for a moment. Then she turned. Show me, she said.

Her Mother's Inheritance

It was a small box, lacquered black with a pattern worked into the surface in a dark red that was nearly invisible except at certain angles—the same interlocking geometric pattern she had noticed on Iskender's kaftan, the one her eyes kept sliding off of. He set it on the desk between them and stepped back, which she appreciated.

She had no memory of her mother. Handan Kaya had died of fever when Nura was three, which was long enough ago that the loss had become structural—not an absence she felt acutely but an absence that had shaped the room of her, the places where something should have been and wasn't. Her uncle did not speak of his dead sister. Her father had left when she was five. Nura knew her mother primarily through the object of her own face, which her aunt had once told her was almost identical to Handan's, and through the color indigo, which her uncle used in certain moods as a synonym for her name.

She opened the box.

Inside: a folded letter, dense with small handwriting. A ring of dark metal—iron, she thought, until she touched it and felt it was something heavier, something that absorbed light rather than reflecting it. And a stone, smooth and gray, small enough to sit in her palm. Unremarkable. A river stone, almost.

She touched the stone first, because it was the least frightening thing. The moment her fingers closed around it, she felt the warmth in her palms—not the

uncontrolled surge of the dye workshop, but a controlled warmth, like a handed lamp. And with the warmth, something else. A sound that was not quite a sound. A voice that was not quite a voice.

She heard her mother.

Not words, exactly—a texture of words, a cadence, the specific quality of a particular person’s speech. She heard her mother laugh. She heard her mother argue with someone in a language she did not speak but whose emotional content was unmistakable. She heard her mother say her name—not Nura but something before Nura, the name her mother had apparently intended before circumstances had dictated otherwise—and the sound of it, that almost-name, went through her like a key in a lock she had not known was closed.

She put the stone down.

Iskender did not ask. He waited.

She unfolded the letter.

It was not addressed to her. It was addressed to whoever finds her, and this phrasing—the uncertainty of it, the acknowledgment that Handan had not known who would ultimately deliver this to her daughter or when—was somehow the thing that broke through the composure Nura had been maintaining since she walked through his door.

She read it anyway. It took time, because the handwriting was small and dense and occasionally switched languages, and because she had to stop twice.

Her mother had known she was dying before the fever took her. Not from the fever—she had been warned, by sources she did not name in the letter, that someone was working against the Residue Society, that someone had decided the weakening binding on the old remnant was an opportunity rather than a crisis. Someone who believed that the power inside a remnant of that age and magnitude, properly channeled, could do extraordinary things. This someone had moved against several members of the Society in the preceding months. Handan had moved her daughter to her brother’s workshop and removed herself from her daughter’s life in order to keep Nura out of sight, and had then been caught anyway.

The fever, the letter said, was not natural.

There is a name in the city, her mother had written, who is very old and not what he appears. He calls himself a collector. He has been collecting for a long time—objects, knowledge, Vasita. Do not let him find you before you find your power. And find your power. You have more of it than I did, I believe, though I only held you three years and cannot be certain. What I am certain of is this: the binding will not hold indefinitely. When it breaks, the remnant will need to go somewhere. The only somewhere it can go safely is back into the deep earth, which requires a Vasita of significant strength to perform the return. I was that Vasita. Now I am not. I am sorry, little one. I intended to be there for all of it.

I intended so many things.

Nura refolded the letter. She held it in her lap for a moment. Then she put it in her pocket, beside the card that had brought her here, and looked up at Iskender Aras.

Tell me about the collector, she said.

What the Collector Wants

His name changed with the decades, which was one of the ways Iskender had tracked him across the city's long history without initially understanding what he was tracking. He appeared in records under a dozen names stretching back to the late Byzantine period—always a man of middle age, always wealthy, always associated with collections of antiquities and unusual objects, always present in the years surrounding significant disturbances in the city's deep places.

His current name was Murat Deniz. He operated as an antiquities dealer with offices near the Grand Bazaar and a reputation in certain European circles for locating objects of unusual provenance. He was known to be ruthless in acquisition and extraordinarily knowledgeable about the pre-Islamic history of the city—too knowledgeable, in ways that had puzzled historians who occasionally consulted him and could not account for his specificity.

He was, Iskender had concluded after twenty years of careful study, himself a kind of remnant. Not the blind hunger of the things trapped in the deep places—he retained his mind, his will, his selfhood. But he had been touched, long ago, by something old enough to have changed him at a fundamental level. Given him time, and certain abilities, and an appetite that had not decreased with the centuries.

He wanted the remnant, Iskender told her, not to destroy it but to contain it differently. To take its power into himself, which he believed was possible and Iskender believed was not, or at least not without consequences Deniz was willing to discount. The binding had been weakening for a decade. Iskender believed Deniz had been accelerating the weakening—finding the locations where the binding was anchored in the city’s architecture and introducing stress at those points. He had been subtle about it. It had taken Iskender years to identify the pattern.

Handan had identified it before Iskender, Nura said, reading between what he was telling her.

Yes. She confronted him about it directly, which was—he paused. She was very brave. Not always careful in proportion to her bravery.

And he killed her for it.

I believe so. I cannot prove it.

Nura looked at her hands. The iron ring from the box was on her right hand now; she had put it on without consciously deciding to and it had fit as if made for her, which it probably had been. It felt like wearing a second skin—something that understood the structure of her hand and sat within it rather than on top of it.

How does a binding work, she said. Specifically.

He looked at her with the particular attention of a teacher who has just been surprised by a student. A binding of this nature—a containment of a remnant of this age—requires a Vasita to act as the anchor. To take the remnant’s energy into themselves and then direct it downward, into the deep earth, where it can disperse slowly over centuries at a depth too profound to affect the surface. It is not a small thing to undertake. The Vasita who performed the original binding paid a significant price for it.

What price.

Fifteen years. Approximately. She aged fifteen years in the performing of it and never fully recovered what the process cost her physically. She died at fifty-two and looked seventy.

Nura thought about this. About fifteen years of her seventeen-year-old life, taken in a night. About her mother's letter. About the voice-that-was-not-a-voice when she touched the stone, the specific quality of her mother's laugh.

Is there another way, she said. Not me as the anchor. Something else.

I have been looking for another way for three years, he said. Since your mother died. I have not found one. The remnant will not accept a non-Vasita anchor—it has its own nature, and that nature requires a living channel of sufficient capacity. You are the only Vasita I have found in Istanbul in three years who has both the bloodline strength and the capacity that the binding requires.

She stood and walked to the window. The street below was ordinary—a man selling bread from a cart, two women with covered heads and shopping baskets, a European in a too-warm coat looking at a map. The ordinary enormous texture of a city that did not know what was in its foundations.

All right, she said. Then we need to find the binding's anchor points before Deniz does, and we need to do it before the binding fails on its own. She turned around. I have a list of conditions.

He had not expected conditions. She could see it in his face and found, to her surprise, that she liked having surprised him.

Tell me, he said.

The Price of Conditions

Her conditions were three.

First: she would not be kept from information. Not about the remnant, not about the binding, not about what her mother had known and done. Everything Iskender had, she would have access to. She was not a tool to be pointed at the problem—she was a person undertaking a task, and people undertaking tasks made better decisions when they had all the information.

Second: she would continue to have a life. She would not disappear into this building and this work. She had people who depended on her—a cousin who needed someone to lie for her, an uncle who needed someone to manage the back accounts that he did not have the patience for, a neighborhood of small daily relationships that had been the texture of her existence for fourteen years. She would not abandon all of it.

Third: when it was over, whatever it cost her, she would be told the truth about the cost before she paid it. Not after. Not when it was too late to choose differently.

He agreed to all three without hesitation, which told her he had been prepared to agree to more and was somewhat relieved she had not asked for it.

Good, she said. Then start with the anchor points. Where are they and who else knows where they are.

Over the following weeks, Nura learned the underside of Istanbul.

She had always known the city above—the market routes and the ferry schedules and which streets flooded in rain and which coffeehouses served the strong bitter variety her uncle preferred. Now she learned the city below. The ancient cisterns, their columns standing in still water, their depths unmeasured. The fragments of Byzantine wall that still stood in certain courtyards, touching their foundations to foundations older than themselves. The mosques whose architects had built on platforms of stone that predated Islam by a thousand years and had never asked what was in the stone.

The binding had seven anchor points distributed across the city, each one coinciding with a place of deep historical significance. Iskender had identified four of them with confidence and two more with reasonable certainty. The seventh he had been searching for since Handan died and had not found.

Deniz, they believed, had found it. And had already stressed two of the anchor points to a degree that made Iskender's instruments register the equivalent of alarm.

We have perhaps six weeks, he told her. Before the binding fails naturally. If Deniz accelerates his interference at the remaining points, less.

Then we need to stop him accelerating it, she said. And find the seventh point. In what order do we do these things.

He gave her the look again—the surprised-teacher look. I had assumed we would locate the seventh point first.

If he stresses another anchor point while we are looking for the seventh, we may not have time to use the information. She had the city map spread on his desk, the seven possible points marked with his notation. She had been studying it for three days and had begun to feel the pattern in it—the way the points were distributed with a logic that was not geographical but something else. Something she needed more information to name. We need to meet him directly, she said. Not to fight him—not yet. I want to understand what he is.

I have told you what he is.

You have told me what you know about him, which is not the same thing. She touched the iron ring. He is old. Old things have patterns. I want to see his pattern.

Iskender was quiet for a moment. How do you propose to meet him.

He is an antiquities dealer. I am a girl from a dye workshop with no money and no status. She looked up. But the Residue Society has been collecting objects of unusual provenance for decades. Some of them must have market value. She paused. Sell him something he wants. And let me be the person who brings it to him.

He stared at her.

You are seventeen years old, he said.

My mother was apparently dealing with this problem at twenty, she said. And you have told me she was good at it. How old were you when you started.

He did not answer. But the following morning, he showed her the collection room.

The Collector's Eye

Murat Deniz received her in an office above his showroom that smelled of cedar and old paper and something underneath both of them that she recognized without being able to name—the same quality she had felt in the deep cistern Iskender had taken her to, the quality of great age and compressed patience.

He was not what she had expected. She had imagined someone visibly wrong—misaligned in some way that would be apparent to her new awareness, the way a note played on a poorly tuned instrument created a vibration you felt in the wrong register. Instead he was a man of perhaps forty-five in a beautifully made suit, with a scholar's careful hands and eyes of a remarkable pale gray that watched everything with an attention that never quite settled.

She had brought him a small bronze lamp from Iskender's collection—genuine Byzantine, eighth century, catalogued and documented. A thing of real value and no supernatural significance whatsoever. She had insisted on the latter. She was not going to use Iskender's significant objects as bargaining chips before she understood the game.

He examined it for four minutes without speaking, turning it in those careful hands, holding it to the light from the window, running a thumbnail along the seam between the lamp body and its handle. Then he set it down.

What do you want for it, he said.

Information, she said. I am researching the pre-Ottoman sacred sites of the city. Not academically—I want to know where they are now. What is built on them.

He looked at her for a long time. She held the look without flinching and felt, with a clarity that had been growing since she began working with Iskender, the warmth in her ring hand responding to whatever was in him. Not hostile—curious. The ring was curious about what he was.

The warmth told her something else too: he recognized her. Not her specifically, perhaps, but what she was. A Vasita. He had been around enough of them, for long enough, that her nature was readable to him the way literacy let you read without thinking about individual letters.

He said: Who sent you here.

I found you myself, she said. You came recommended.

By whom.

A woman in the spice market. She said you knew things that other scholars didn't. That you had lived in this city long enough to know its older history.

The pause that followed was its own kind of answer. He picked up the lamp again.

There is a site near the Hippodrome, he said, that most people walk past without knowing what they are passing. A section of older foundation, exposed in a courtyard behind a residential building. If you place your hand on the stone—he looked at her sideways—some people find it interesting. He set the lamp down. I will keep this. And I will give you a name—a historian, a genuine one, who has documented some of what you are looking for. Consider it a courtesy. He wrote a name on a card and held it out.

She took it. She stood.

One more thing, he said, as she moved toward the door. The ring you are wearing. Where did you get it.

She looked down at the iron ring as if noticing it for the first time. My mother left it to me.

His face did something she could not fully read—several things happening behind it at the same time. Then: Your mother had good taste. He turned back to

the lamp. Good afternoon.

She walked down the stairs and into the street and kept walking for two full blocks before she allowed herself to feel how much her hands were shaking.

Then she took out a notebook and wrote down everything she had noticed. The smell. The gray eyes. The way the ring had warmed when she entered his office and how it had responded to his attention when he saw it. The fact that his stillness, which had seemed like composure from a distance, was up close something different—an absence of small movement, of the tiny habitual adjustments that living bodies made without their owners noticing. As if the machinery of him ran on a different economy than ordinary human life.

And one thing more. When he looked at the ring, there had been recognition in his face—not the recognition of a collector identifying a rare object. Something older than that. Something personal.

He knew the ring. He knew what it was and perhaps who it had belonged to before her mother.

She was almost certain he was afraid of it.

The Seventh Point

The historian's name was Dr. Lena Hartmann, a German woman of perhaps forty who taught at the new university and lived in a cluttered apartment in Pera full of maps and correspondence and three cats who ignored Nura completely when she arrived. She had been expecting Nura—Deniz had apparently sent a note ahead, which told Nura several things about the nature of the game being played that she filed away carefully.

She does not know what she is helping, Nura told Iskender when she returned that evening. Deniz uses her as a resource. She is a genuine scholar—she knows the city's deep history better than anyone I have met, including you, in terms of the physical record. But she does not know what the sites she has documented are.

Did she tell you about the seventh point.

Not by name. But she showed me something. She had spread the map on his desk and marked a location near the old sea walls, on the Marmara coast. This stretch of wall, she said, is the oldest standing construction in the city. Earlier than anything else still above ground. The foundation stone below it is even older—pre-Greek. Hartmann documented it three years ago. She says the stone is unlike any other construction material in the city. A different composition. She thinks it was imported.

Iskender stared at the map for a long time.

Three years ago, he said finally. Your mother died three years ago.

Yes. Nura kept her voice level. I think Deniz directed Hartmann's research toward that wall. I think he needed the seventh point documented so he could find it and stress it, and he did not want to attract attention by looking for it himself. He used her. She looked up. He also told her I was interested in it, which means he knows I am looking for the anchor points, which means he knows who I am.

He knew the moment you walked into his office.

I know. But knowing and acting on knowing are different things. He has not moved against me. I think he is watching to see what I do next.

Or he is deciding whether you are more useful to him as an ally or an obstacle.

She had thought the same thing. The ring warm on her hand, its weight familiar now after three weeks. Tell me about this ring, she said. My mother's ring. What is it.

He was quiet for a moment. Then: It is a binding object. One of the original tools used to perform the first containment, four and a half centuries ago. It was made by the Vasita who performed the binding—she made it as an anchor for her own power during the process, a kind of external reservoir. After the binding, it retained some of what she had channeled.

And Deniz recognized it.

He was there, Iskender said quietly. Or present in the city. The Vasita who performed the original binding worked against his interference, four hundred and forty years ago. He has been looking for that ring since she took it from him.

She did not ask how. She could feel the how—the way the ring sat on her hand, the way it responded to her. The original Vasita had taken it from him as a source of power, or as a precaution, or as both. And it had passed down—through what channels, she did not yet know, but it had passed—and arrived in her mother's hands, and then in hers.

He wants the remnant's power, she said slowly. He has wanted it for four and a half centuries. And he has been accelerating the binding's failure because

he believes that when it fails, he can absorb what comes out. She paused. But the ring would interfere with that. A Vasita holding the ring would interfere with that. Which means —

Which means you are not simply a resource to him, Iskender said. You are a threat.

She looked at the map. At the seventh point, the old sea wall, the oldest stones in the city.

Then we cannot wait for him to move, she said. We need to perform the re-binding before he reaches the seventh anchor point. She looked up. How long do I have before I am ready.

Iskender met her eyes. I do not know. I have never trained a Vasita. I have only observed them.

Then we are going to find out together, she said. Starting tonight.

The Deep Below the City

She was not ready. She knew this with reasonable certainty on the night they went to the sea wall, three weeks later, because the power in her hands was still unpredictable—capable of great things in controlled conditions and unreliable when she was afraid.

She went anyway, which was perhaps what being ready actually meant.

The old sea wall at midnight was a different place than it was during the day—emptied of the fishermen and the walkers and the children, stripped back to its own long nature. The stones were enormous, each one the size of a cart, fitted together with an almost organic precision that spoke of hands that had understood stone the way most people understood conversation. She could feel them before she touched them. The ring warmed steadily, persistently, as if it recognized where it was.

Deniz was already there.

She had expected this. She had not told Iskender she expected it because she had known he would try to come with her, and she had known with equal certainty that Iskender's presence would be a vulnerability. Deniz would use him. He was old enough and practiced enough at leverage to find the right angle on any human relationship and press it.

She had come alone, which was either very brave or very stupid.

He stood at the wall's base, one hand flat against the stone, and he was lit from below—or not lit, the opposite of that, a kind of darkness that was more concentrated than the surrounding night, that moved with him rather than being cast by him. He turned when she approached. He did not look surprised.

I wondered which of you would come, he said. I expected the old man.

He would have been more afraid, she said. Fear is useful to you.

He considered her with those still gray eyes. You are very young.

You keep saying things that are meant to discourage me. She stopped twelve feet from him. The ring was very warm. The warmth had moved up her wrist, her forearm—not painful but comprehensive, the way a sound could fill a room. It knows you, she said. The ring. It remembers what you did to the woman who made it.

Something moved in his face. It is strange, he said, to be remembered by an object. I have outlived every person who ever feared me. But objects are more patient than people.

My mother feared you, she said. And you killed her for it.

He was quiet for a moment. She was inconvenient. He said it without cruelty, which was almost worse. She had found something I did not want found. I would have preferred to negotiate.

The power was fully in both hands now, both arms, climbing her shoulders. She had never felt it this far up her body. It was not comfortable. It was also, she recognized, not out of control. It was responding to what it encountered here—the depth of the seventh anchor point below her feet, the compressed centuries of the wall beside her, and whatever Deniz was radiating that was not quite human and had not been, she estimated, for a very long time.

What he had taken from one of the old things in the deep places, so long ago, was not making him stronger, she realized. It was making him less—carving out the human parts of him by degrees, century by century, until what remained was appetite and patience and the intelligence that served them. He had been extraordinary once. She could feel the shadow of it, the outline of what he had been before he had made his first bargain with the deep residue.

She understood, suddenly, that she felt sorry for him. And she understood, equally suddenly, that this was the most dangerous thing she could feel right now.

She knelt and pressed both hands to the ground.

The seventh anchor point was exactly where Hartmann's research had placed it—deep below the wall's foundation, in the bedrock where the city's oldest significant act had been performed by someone whose name was lost. She felt it the way you felt the rung of a ladder when you found it in darkness—by its solidity, its specificity, its difference from everything around it. She felt the binding stretched thin across it, cobweb-thin after four centuries, still holding but barely, barely.

She also felt the remnant.

It was not what she had expected. Not a monster, not a coherent malevolence. It was vast and unspecific and very tired—an ancient energy that had been compressed and confined for four hundred years and wanted, more than anything, to disperse. To return to wherever it had come from. It was not straining against the binding. It was simply waiting for the binding to fail so it could finally be done.

She understood what her mother had understood.

This was not a re-binding. There was nothing left to re-bind. What it needed was permission to go.

She opened her hands.

After the Frequency Changes

She lost six years.

Not fifteen, as the original Vasita had—she was stronger than that woman had been, or the remnant was further dispersed by now, or both. But six years of her own life, taken in approximately four minutes of kneeling against the old stone, channeling something that had been waiting four centuries for someone to open the door and let it out. She felt them go the way you felt a breath leave your body—not painful, not traumatic. Just done. And then cold and empty and the smell of salt from the Marmara, and Deniz standing over her saying her name in a voice that was almost, almost afraid.

She had not bound it. She had released it. Let it pass through her and back into the deep earth, back into the real deep where the old energies eventually went when nothing was holding them in place—where they were absorbed and neutralized by the simple enormous weight of geological time. It was not what anyone had planned. It was what the situation required.

Deniz had not moved against her while she did it. She thought about this later, the way you thought about something that had surprised you by being different from its own stated nature. He had stood and watched and not interfered, and she did not know if this was because the ring had been too dangerous to approach, or because even four and a half centuries of wanting had not fully extinguished some older sense of what was right, or simply because he

had looked at her face in the moment she understood what needed to happen and recognized something there that gave him pause.

When it was over he was gone. She did not know where he went. He was a man of many names and many decades of practice at disappearing. Iskender said they would see him again, eventually—things with his kind of patience always resurfaced. Nura thought he was probably right and also thought that when Deniz resurfaced, he would be dealing with a somewhat different problem than the one he had anticipated.

He had wanted the power of the remnant for himself. The power of the remnant was gone, properly gone, for the first time since the fall of Constantinople. There was nothing left for him to collect.

She was twenty-three in a seventeen-year-old body for approximately eight months, which was disorienting in ways she had not expected—not physically, but in the strange tax it placed on her relationships with people who did not know what had happened. Yildiz noticed and asked if she had been ill. Kerem noticed and did not ask. Dr. Hartmann noticed, the second time Nura visited her, and said only that some experiences showed on a person, and made tea without being asked.

The Residue Society, which turned out to have six active members besides Iskender, received her with a combination of relief and careful apology for what had been asked of her. She accepted the apology and joined the Society on the condition that her conditions from the beginning remained operative. They agreed without hesitation. She suspected they would have agreed to more.

She moved out of her uncle's workshop and into a set of rooms near Iskender's building, which she could now afford because the Society had resources and she had proved herself essential to them in a way that had nothing to do with her ability and everything to do with how she thought. She continued to visit her uncle and Yildiz every week. She continued to cover for Yildiz, who continued to need covering for.

She did not tell them what had happened. She told Yildiz she had found a new position, with better wages, with a scholarly society that needed a researcher. Yildiz said that sounded boring. Nura said it was mostly boring. This

was not entirely true but was not entirely false either.

The ring stayed on her hand. It was quieter now—the ancient anger of the woman who had made it, four hundred and forty years ago, had dispersed along with the remnant it had spent four centuries resisting. What remained was something more personal. An object that knew her. That had known her mother. That remembered, in whatever way objects remembered, the full length of the line it had traveled to arrive on her hand in a dye workshop in September of 1893.

She wore it and thought sometimes about her mother touching this same metal, feeling this same weight. She thought about the voice that had come from the stone in Iskender's box—the laugh, the argument in the unknown language, the almost-name. She thought about what it meant to inherit not just an object or an ability but a whole position in something larger than yourself, a role in a story that had been running for centuries before your name was in it.

She thought she might write it down someday. All of it. The dye workshop. The cracked vat. The card with the eye on it. The man who collected impossibilities and the woman who had been his most significant obstacle and passed that obstacle on to her daughter like a good coat—practical, warm, sized to grow into.

She thought she might write it down.

But first there was work to do, and the city was very old, and its deep places did not stay quiet for long.



End of Book One

THE BLOOD OF FORGOTTEN GODS

Book One



Nura's story continues in Book Two — coming soon.

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